

Chapter No. 1

Introduction to civics and citizenship

Civics is the study of right and duties of citizenship, focusing on relationship between individuals and their government.

It examines how system works, roles and responsibilities of citizen and importance of civic engagement in maintaining a democratic society.

■ Defination of civics:

Important defination of civics stated by different philosophers are as follows:-

- Civics is the study of theoretical, political and practical aspects of citizenship, as well as right and duties. (John J. Patrick)

- Civic education is vital for empowering citizens to understand their rights and responsibilities and to participate effectively in self-governance. (Thomas Jefferson)

- Civics is the study of civic life and its related issues. (Patrick Gaddis)

- Civics is a social science dealing with the rights and duties of citizens.

(Merriam-Webster Dictionary)

■ Defination of citizenship:

Citizenship refers to the status of being a recognized member of a state or nation, with specific rights and responsibilities.

- A citizen is someone who has the right and capacity to participate in the deliberative or judicial administration of the state. (Aristotle)
- Citizenship is the legal bond between an individual and state, granting the individual rights and protection under the law in return for fulfilling certain duties as a member of that state. (UNO)
- citizenship is defined as the link between an individual and a state, where the individual is recognized as a subject of that state with rights and duties. (UNESCO)

■ Defination of civil engagement:

Civic engagement refers to the involvement of individuals and communities in the decision-making processes that affect their lives. It encompasses a wide range of activities.

- The connections among individuals, social networks and the norms of reciprocity and trustworthiness that arise from them
(Robert Putnam)

- Participation in public affairs, expressing opinions, and striving to influence the political and social environment.
(Eleanor Roosevelt)

- An active involvement in social reforms and community service.
(Jane Addams)

■ Historical evolution of civic participation

Civic participation has undergone significant evolution throughout history, shaped by changing societal values, technological advancement and political landscapes.

Its roots date back to ancient democratic societies where participation in public life was considered a civic duty. Here's a brief overview:-

- (i) **Ancient civilization:** The ancient Athens is the Birthplace of Democracy, where direct democracy allowed citizens to vote on laws and policies. In Rome, civic duties

included military services and public services.

(ii) **Medieval period:** During Middle Ages, civic participation was limited due to "feudalism". Feudal systems often restricted political involvement to the nobility and clergy, while common people had few channels for participation. Power was held by monarchs.

(iii) **Enlightenment Era:** The enlightenment brought forth idea of "individual rights", liberty and democracy. Thinkers like John Locke and Jean-Jacques Rousseau advocated for more inclusive political participation.

(iv) **Age of Revolution (18th - 19th century):**

The American Revolution (1776) and French Revolution (1789) were pivotal movements in expanding civic participation, advocating for rights of people to participate in government. The 19th century saw significant expansion of civic participation, with movements advocating for universal suffrages, labor rights and social reforms.

(v) **20th century:** In 20th century, the feminist movement, civil right movement and other social movements pushed for

greater inclusion and equality. Decolonization after world war II resulted in newly independent nations establishing their own democratic system.

(vi) **21st century:** Digital participation has transformed civic participation. Social media platforms and online petitions has empowered individuals to mobilize quickly. This era also sees a focus on global citizenship and transnational issues.

■ Types of Citizenship:

Citizenship can be classified into various types. Here are the different types of citizenship commonly recognized.

(i) **Active citizenship:** Active citizenship involves individuals taking an active part/role in their communities and society. This includes like voting, volunteering and community organizing. It also help to improve society.

(ii) **Participatory citizenship:** This type of citizenship emphasizes involvement in collective decision-making processes. This is focused on participation in democratic institutions and community dialogues. It shapes society.

- (iii) **Digital citizenship:** Digital citizenship refers to the responsible, ethical and effective use of technology by individuals to engage in society, politics and communication online. Digital citizenship has become essential for participating in modern world.
- (iv) **Global citizenship:** Global citizenship recognises shared global responsibilities and interconnectedness. It includes international cooperation, human right advocacy and environmental awareness. It extends beyond borders.
- (v) **Ecological/Environmental citizenship:** It is centered on the responsibility to protect the environment and promote sustainability. It emphasizes the role citizens play in conserving natural resources and protecting the planet for future generations.
- (vi) **Economic citizenship:** Economic citizenship relates to the rights and responsibilities of citizens in economic spheres, particularly concerning access to economic resources, financial literacy and the ability to participate in economy.
- (vii) **Constructive citizenship:** It refers to the positive and active engagement of citizens.

in their communities and societies to promote common good. It involves active participation, critical thinking, inclusivity and accountability.

(viii) **Cultural citizenship:** Cultural citizenship focuses on the rights of individuals to participate in and contribute to the cultural life of their community and society. It emphasizes the ability of citizens to express their cultural traditions, languages and beliefs freely and without discrimination.

■ Relationship between Democracy & Citizenship

The relationship between democracy and citizenship is fundamental and deeply interconnected, as each concept relies on and reinforces the other. While democracy emphasizes on the participation of the people in governing processes, citizenship refers to the legal and social status that allows individuals to engage in their democratic practices. The relation between both forms the backbone of any democratic society. Below is the comprehensive examination how both relate to each other.

- **Democracy as system of Governance:** Democracy is a form of government where power is vested in the people, exercised either directly or through elected representatives. In democracy, the authority of government is derived from the people. Elections allow the people to choose their representatives. These representatives govern according to rule of law.

- **Citizenship as legal and social status:** Citizenship involves both the privileges of belonging to a nation and obligations that come with it. It grants individuals local legal recognition, entitling a state and protection of rights. Citizens participate in society not only by fulfilling their legal duties but also engaging in broader civic activities such as public discourse.

- **Democratic citizenship and political participation:** Democratic citizenship emphasizes active involvement in the political life of community. Citizens exercise their right to vote and also stay informed about public issues and engage in dialogue that shape policy.

- **Citizenship and protection of rights in Democracy:** One of the hallmarks of a democratic

system is its commitment to protecting the rights of its citizens. These right allows individuals to express their opinions, participate in civil society and challenge unjust law or policies.

- **Balance of rights and Responsibilities in citizenship:** Citizenship in a democracy is a two-way relationship. While the state provides the citizens with rights that protect their freedom and dignity, citizens must also contribute to the maintainance of democratic system by fulfilling their responsibilities.

- **Role of Education in Democratic citizenship:** For a democracy to function effectively, its citizen must be knowledgeable about how government works, their rights and their responsibilities. Civic education plays a crucial role in preparing citizens.

- **Global citizenship and democracy:** In the age of globalization the idea of global citizenship is emerging, where individuals see themselves as a part of global community with responsibilities to uphold human rights, environmental protection and

social justice across borders.

- **Civic engagement and strengthening democracy:** Beyond voting, democratic citizenship involves a broader engagement with civil society. Participating in public/community services, advocacy and civic groups allows citizens to contribute to the common good and shape public policy.

conclusion:-

The relation between democracy and citizenship is essential for the functioning of democratic societies. Citizenship in a democracy is not just a passive status but an active role that individuals play in shaping their governance and society. Active, engaged and informed citizens are backbone of healthy democracy.